From Ocean Accounts to Policy Action

Crafting a Policy Brief — Ocean Accounting Clinic Pt. 2

Day 3 — 1 April 2026

GLOBAL OCEAN ACCOUNTS PARTNERSHIP

What You Will Leave With Today

Two concrete outputs you can use immediately

COMPASS Message Box

Your elevator pitch for ocean accounts policy relevance — a structured tool to communicate what matters and why.

Draft Policy Brief

A 2–4 page document a decision-maker can act on — evidence-based, jargon-free, and actionable.

Part 1: Message Box
09:10 – 10:30

Break

Part 2: Policy Brief
10:45 – 12:00

The Science-Policy Gap

Scientists and policymakers read in opposite directions

🔬 How Scientists Present

1. **Background** — the literature and context
2. **Methods** — how we did it
3. **Results** — what we found
4. **Conclusions** — what it means

🏛️ What Policymakers Want

1. **Results** — what did you find?
2. **So what?** — why does it matter to me?
3. **Background** — only if I need it

The challenge is not relevance. The challenge is *translation*.

Science Is One Input Among Many

Policy decisions are shaped by six intersecting forces

Policy Actors

The people involved — ministers, advisors, lobbyists, community leaders

Networks

Relationships and alliances that shape who listens to whom

Institutions

The formal rules, norms, and procedures that constrain decisions

Ideas

Beliefs, worldviews, and paradigms that frame what seems possible

Events

Shocks, crises, and windows of opportunity that open the door

Socioeconomic Context

Economic conditions, inequality, and development priorities

Your ocean accounts enter as evidence. A good brief positions evidence within this landscape.

Know Your Audience

Different readers ask different questions of the same data

Finance Ministry

“How much does the ocean contribute to GDP?”

Environment Ministry

“What is the state of our marine ecosystems?”

Planning Agency

“Where should we invest in coastal infrastructure?”

International Body

“How do our accounts support SDG 14 reporting?”

Before writing, name a specific person as your reader.

Tool 1 — The COMPASS Message Box

A framework to distill your ocean accounts story into one clear message

PROBLEMS

What challenges or gaps exist that your audience should know about?

SOLUTIONS

What can be done? What actions address the problems?

ISSUE

Your Topic

BENEFITS

What happens if we act? What does success look like?

SO WHAT

Why does this matter to *your specific audience*?

Message Box — Worked Example

Ocean Accounts for the Global Biodiversity Framework

PROBLEMS

GBF targets require data on marine ecosystems; most countries lack baselines and monitoring capacity.

SOLUTIONS

Compile ocean accounts using SEEA EA + GOAP guidance to provide standardised data.

ISSUE

Ocean accounts for the GBF

BENEFITS

Meet reporting obligations, attract conservation finance, and inform marine spatial planning.

SO WHAT

Without ocean accounts, governments cannot credibly report on GBF progress or access funding.

Your Turn — Complete Your Message Box

Follow these five steps to build your own message

1. **Name your target audience**
   Who is the specific person you want to reach? What is their role?

2. **Write the Issue**
   One phrase that captures the topic — keep it simple and concrete.

3. **Fill in “So What”**
   This is the hardest part. Ask yourself: if a minister said “why should I care?” — what would you say?

4. **Fill in Problems and Solutions**
   What gaps exist? What actions can address them?

5. **Fill in Benefits**
   What happens if your audience acts? Paint the picture of success.

20 min individual | 10 min pair share

Tool 2 — The Policy Brief

Know what you are writing — and what you are not

✅ What a Policy Brief IS

- **Short** — a 5–10 minute read
- **Jargon-free** — plain language throughout
- **Actionable** — specific recommendations
- **Evidence-based** — grounded in data, not opinions

❌ What It Is NOT

- A research paper
- A methods description
- A literature review
- An opinion piece

Think of it as a bridge between your data and a decision — not as a summary of your work.

Anatomy of a GOAP Policy Brief

Seven sections, each with a clear purpose

1

Title

Country + topic in 10 words

2

Key Messages

3–4 bullets (write last!)

3

Context

Lead with the reader's world

4

Findings

One key finding + one number

5

Implications

Link to a policy instrument

6

Recommendations

2–3 specific actions

Writing Tips

Translate jargon and follow five core principles

Jargon Translation

~~"Extent account"~~	→	**"We mapped X hectares of coral reef"**
~~"Condition index declined"~~	→	**"Reef health dropped 15% in 5 years"**
~~"Ecosystem services valued at"~~	→	**"Coastal protection saves $X million/year"**
~~"GVA contribution"~~	→	**"Ocean industries contribute X% of GDP"**

Writing Principles

- ✓ **Lead with what you know** — not how you learned it
- ✓ **One or two key numbers** — not a full table
- ✓ **No methods or statistical details**
- ✓ **Write for someone outside your field**
- ✓ **Every sentence answers "so what?"**

Real GOAP Briefs — One Framework, Many Angles

The same structure adapts to different countries, audiences, and policy questions

🌍 Ocean Accounts for the GBF

Audience: International biodiversity community

Policy angle: Conservation targets and reporting obligations

🐠 Belize Coral Reef Condition

Audience: Fisheries department

Policy angle: MPA management and reef monitoring

📈 South Africa Ocean Economy

Audience: Treasury / finance ministry

Policy angle: Blue economy investment and growth strategy

🏝️ Maldives Laamu Atoll

Audience: Tourism ministry

Policy angle: Reef-dependent tourism value and protection

Same seven-section structure. Different stories, audiences, and recommendations.

Your Turn — Draft Your Brief

Four blocks, 40 minutes. Start writing now.

1. **Title and Context**
   Set the scene: who is your reader, and what world do they operate in?
   10 min

2. **What the Accounts Show**
   Present your key finding with one compelling number. No methods.
   15 min

3. **Recommendations**
   2–3 specific actions your reader can take. Be concrete.
   10 min

4. **Key Messages**
   Write these *last* — 3–4 bullets that capture the brief's essence.
   5 min

Peer review: swap briefs with your neighbour. Can they explain your main finding in one sentence?